

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, sunny, windy, very cold, an afternoon snow shower, high 35. **Tonight**, cloudy, blustery, cold, low 28. **Tomorrow**, cloudy, brisk, cold, high 36. Weather map is on Page B8.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



Two sprawling detention centers in Kurdish-controlled northeastern Syria house more than 27,000 family members of ISIS militants.

Volatility Grows in Syrian Camps Holding Families of ISIS Fighters

By ALISSA J. RUBIN

AL HOL CAMP, Syria — The arid steppes of northeastern Syria stretch almost uninterrupted to the Iraqi border, the emptiness broken only by the occasional oil derrick, until the road comes to a sprawling prison camp.

A chain-link fence topped with barbed wire surrounds the vast compound, and supply trucks line the route for more than half a mile outside the camp's gates. This is Al Hol detention camp, where most detainees are family members — wives, sisters, children — of fighters for the terrorist group Islamic State, or ISIS. More than 8,000 fighters themselves are in prisons nearby.

For years, ISIS ruled large parts of Syria and neighboring Iraq, brutally enforcing its strict interpretation of Islamic law. As

As U.S. Steps Back, It Wants Damascus to Take Over Control

Kurdish-led Syrian forces backed by the United States battled to reclaim that land, they detained thousands of ISIS fighters and tens of thousands of their relatives.

U.S. forces entrusted their Syrian Kurdish allies with guarding the ISIS detainees and families. But now, the Pentagon is drawing down its troops in Syria, and there are indications that U.S. officials want Syria's new government to take responsibility for the prisons and detention camps.

This is part of a larger govern-

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E.P.A. Is Set to Loosen Rules On Exposure to Formaldehyde

By HIROKO TABUCHI

The Trump administration is proposing to almost double what's considered safe exposure levels to formaldehyde, a cancer-causing chemical found in many consumer products, as part of a broader overhaul of its approach to regulating carcinogens.

The Environmental Protection Agency under the Biden administration had, for the first time, prepared to regulate formaldehyde based on a fundamental assumption: that there is virtually no safe level of exposure for such carcinogens.

But in a win for the chemicals industry, the E.P.A. under President Trump is upending that approach. A draft memo published by the agency this month assumes a safe threshold exists for formaldehyde.

Doubling the Limit for a Chemical Known to Cause Cancer

Regulating formaldehyde has been highly contentious because it is used in products as varied as furniture and clothes, so many different industries would be affected by any limits.

The proposed new approach, long called for by industry groups, is moving forward under the direction of two E.P.A. officials who were formerly senior directors at a leading chemicals industry group.

The change would almost double the amount of formaldehyde that is considered safe to inhale,

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A Theater Popular Partly Because It's Zzz-Rated

By MAX KIM

SEOUL — The matinee was coming to a gruesome ending on the screen, but in the seats casual conversation mixed with a salvo of ringtones, several of which resulted in long phone calls. Dozens of patrons wandered in and out of the auditorium. One man stopped in the aisle to stretch, his puffer jacket emitting loud polyester swishes with every move.

These are the rhythms of Hollywood Classic, an independent movie theater in Seoul that has a dedicated clientele.

"It's a sanctuary for people in their 60s and older — somewhere you can just sit and pass the time," said Kim Woo-bon, 81, who was sitting in the middle section. "Everybody knows about this place."

For the cinephiles, it is a place to catch long-forgotten flicks on the big screen. For the nostalgia-seekers, the lobby is a well-furnished museum of life in postwar South Korea, filled with everything from vintage rice cookers to old children's textbooks. But most just come to hang out.

"A lot of people just come and sleep in their seats because they have nowhere better to be," said Mr. Kim, a retired foreman.

Older Patrons Take In a Film, Chat or Nap

"Then they wake up and watch for a bit and then doze off again."

The theater's target audience is rapidly growing. Years of falling fertility rates have turned South Korea into one of the fastest-aging societies in the world. Last year, for the first time in the

country's history, citizens in their 70s outnumbered those in their 20s.

But older residents have scant options for leisure, said Hyeri Shin, a professor of gerontology at Kyung Hee University in Seoul.

"There is growing demand among older South Koreans for different forms of recreation, but their choices are still limited to simple activities like 'resting' or

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A Monday concert late last month at Hollywood Classic in Seoul, a two-screen movie theater that caters to an older audience.

A Prime Target For Scam Calls, 50 Times a Day

By NICK KEPPLER

The calls start about 7 a.m. and continue until 6 or 7 p.m. On a recent afternoon, Steven Kurutz flipped through his phone's call log. They were coming about every 14 minutes: 10:39 a.m., 11:03, 11:06, 11:25, 11:37, 11:55, 12:06, 12:18.

When Mr. Kurutz, 80, answered, a recorded message asked about his Medicare coverage.

"My name is Laura from health care," a chipper voice said. "We're reaching out to seniors to ensure any unclaimed additional Medicare benefit. You have Medicare Parts A and B, right?"

This call, like most others, claimed to offer Medicare Part C, a type of private insurance, usually marketed as Medicare Advantage, that augments Part A, which covers hospitalization, and Part B, which covers outpatient services. Mr. Kurutz, who lives in South Park Township, Pa., already had the equivalent of a Part C plan. It was included in his retirement package with General Motors, which employed him as a truck repairman for 32 years.

After he pressed 1 for yes, a muffled male voice mumbled something about Medicare parts.

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Fed Cuts Rates As Split Clouds Action in 2026

Unemployment Fears vs. Inflation Anxiety

By COLBY SMITH

The Federal Reserve lowered interest rates by a quarter of a percentage point on Wednesday in a highly contentious decision. The split among policymakers suggested that the central bank may be done lowering borrowing costs for the time being unless there are clear signs that the labor market is weakening further.

The decision to cut for a third meeting in a row shifted interest rates to a new range of 3.5 percent to 3.75 percent. It was the fourth straight vote that was not backed by all members of the 12-person Federal Open Market Committee, underscoring how fractured the central bank has become as it grapples with the risk of rising unemployment and sticky inflation.

Stephen I. Miran, a member of the Board of Governors, opposed the decision in favor of a larger, half-point reduction. It is the third meeting in a row at which Mr. Miran has dissented. He was tapped by President Trump to join the Fed in September and is on a temporary leave of absence from the White House.

Jeffrey R. Schmid, president of the Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City, voted for the Fed to stand pat, as he did in October. He was joined this time by Austan D. Goolsbee, president of the Chicago Fed.

That degree of division is rare for Jerome H. Powell, the Fed chair, who has previously been able to corral his colleagues to move as a largely cohesive group even while navigating tricky economic terrain. The split inside the Fed has only dialed up the pressure on Mr. Powell, who is simultaneously facing attacks from Mr. Trump and contenders seeking to replace him when his term as chair ends in May.

At a news conference after the decision, Mr. Powell said that divisions were only natural given the complicated environment the central bank is navigating. He said he could have made the case either way for the Fed to cut interest rates or pause reductions, describing it as a "close call."

"You've got one tool," he said. "You can't do two things at once."

New projections released on

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Art Sent With Love From a Chinese Jail

The artist Gao Zhen tore letter paper by hand into images for his wife and son, who are also unable to leave China. Page A6.

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Peace Prize Winner Ups Ante

Maria Corina Machado's decision to leave Venezuela to travel to Norway carries risks. News Analysis. PAGE A11

Flaws in Diamond Industry

After decades of growth from mining gemstones, Canada's Northwest Territories are facing a crossroads. PAGE A4



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G.O.P. Infighting in Indiana

Some Republicans have resisted a new congressional map despite lobbying from the White House and threats of political consequences. PAGE A15

Push to Oust Health Secretary

An impeachment bid against Robert F. Kennedy Jr. by Haley Stevens, a House Democrat running for Senate in Michigan, is all but certain to fail. PAGE A17

Effectiveness of Arrests

In high-profile Immigration and Customs Enforcement operations in major cities, most of those arrested had no criminal record, data shows. PAGE A18

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A.I. Divide Yawns at Meta

An us-versus-them mentality has emerged between the company's new artificial intelligence team and longtime top executives. PAGE B1

Trump Makes It Awkward

The president's decision to involve himself in the Warner Bros. deal puts pressure on the Justice Dept. PAGE B1

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A Tip for N.F.L. Hopefuls: Wait

N.F.L. team executives believe the top quarterbacks eligible for the 2026 draft should stay in college. PAGE B6

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Dangerous Female Writers

Shows like "Pluribus" and "Die My Love" take viewers inside the minds of their complex protagonists. PAGE C1

Director Grounded in Success

Ryan Coogler discusses his plans post-"Sinners," and why he isn't particularly interested in judging things. PAGE C1



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Seeking Laughs, and Groans

In her comedy special, the "S.N.L." cast member Sarah Sherman is aiming to make her audience squirm. PAGE D7

An Exasperated Progressive

The left-wing podcaster Jennifer Welch is fed up with President Trump. But Democrats can infuriate her too. PAGE D1

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